

INTERNAL PROPOSAL

Implementation Customer Hub: Platform Comparison & Business Case

A detailed comparison of the custom-built ESM Customer Hub against commercial alternatives, with cost analysis, capability assessment, and strategic rationale.

Prepared for: ESM Solutions Leadership

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Status: Draft for Review

Executive Summary

ESM Solutions needs a customer-facing implementation portal that integrates deeply with our existing Smartsheet, HubSpot, and document generation workflows. After evaluating six platform approaches, the custom-built Customer Hub emerges as the strongest fit.

The evaluation considered commercial implementation management platforms (GuideCX, Rocketlane), project management tools with client portals (Smartsheet Dynamic View, Monday.com), general-purpose portals (SharePoint), and the custom-built solution currently in development.

Key findings:

- **No commercial platform** natively supports AI-powered document generation from customer-uploaded procurement files — our core differentiator
- Commercial platforms that come closest (GuideCX, Rocketlane) would still require significant customization and would not integrate with our existing Smartsheet project plans without middleware
- The custom hub's operating cost (**\$28–76/month**) is a fraction of per-seat commercial alternatives, which range from \$1,200–7,200/year for our team size
- The custom approach provides **full control** over branding, workflow, and customer experience — critical for a product that represents ESM to our institutional clients

Management Review Required: This document contains estimated cost figures and platform capability assessments. Commercial platform pricing should be verified with current vendor quotes before any external distribution. All cost estimates are based on publicly available information as of July 2026.

Problem Statement

Current state

ESM's implementation process involves multiple disconnected tools: Smartsheet for project planning and tracking, HubSpot for intake data, email for meeting recaps and document delivery, and ad-hoc file sharing for deliverables. Customers lack a single view of their implementation status.

Requirements for a solution

The ideal platform must satisfy these requirements, derived from SC and PM workflow needs and customer feedback:

#	REQUIREMENT	PRIORITY	RATIONALE
R1	Real-time project visibility — milestones, action items, RAID log sourced from Smartsheet	Must Have	Customers need current data without SC intervention
R2	AI document generation — 7 document types generated from project data and customer uploads	Must Have	Core IP; reduces SC document prep from hours to minutes
R3	Meeting lifecycle — schedule generation, transcript processing, recap distribution, action item extraction	Must Have	Automates the most time-consuming weekly SC task
R4	Per-customer branding — accent colors, logos, white-labeled experience	Should Have	Institutional clients expect a professional, co-branded portal
R5	HubSpot intake integration — read-only view of onboarding data from HubSpot custom objects	Must Have	Single source of truth for intake data
R6	Role-based access — separate staff dashboard (Admin/SC/PM) and customer portal	Must Have	Customers see only their project; staff see portfolio
R7	Smartsheet as source of truth — no data migration, no parallel data stores	Must Have	PMs and SCs continue working in Smartsheet; hub is the presentation layer
R8	Low operational cost — hosting under \$100/month	Should Have	Implementation tooling should not erode project margins

#	REQUIREMENT	PRIORITY	RATIONALE
R9	Customer self-service — action item updates, document uploads, question submission, search	Should Have	Reduces SC email volume and response latency
R10	Audit and activity tracking — who accessed what, when	Nice to Have	Supports compliance and engagement tracking for institutional clients

Platform Candidates Evaluated

PLATFORM	CATEGORY	DESCRIPTION
ESM Customer Hub	Custom-Built	Next.js 14 web application. Stateless architecture reading from Smartsheet and HubSpot APIs. Claude AI for document generation and transcript processing. Hosted on Azure App Service or IIS.
GuideCX	Implementation Management	Purpose-built customer onboarding and implementation platform. Task management, customer portal, project templates, resource planning. Integrates with CRMs and project tools.
Rocketlane	Implementation Management	Professional services automation (PSA) platform focused on customer onboarding. Project plans, customer portal, document collaboration, time tracking, revenue recognition.
Smartsheet Dynamic View	Native Extension	Smartsheet's built-in feature for sharing filtered, read-only views of sheet data with external users. No separate application required.
Monday.com	Work Management + Client Portal	Work OS with guest/client portal capabilities. Visual project boards, automations, integrations marketplace, dashboards. External sharing via client accounts.
SharePoint Site	General-Purpose Portal	Microsoft 365 SharePoint site with custom pages, document libraries, and Power Automate workflows. Leverages existing M365 tenant.

Feature Comparison Matrix

Each capability is rated: **Full** = native support, **Partial** = possible with workarounds or add-ons, **None** = not feasible.

CAPABILITY	ESM HUB	GUIDECX	ROCKETLANE	SS DYNAMIC VIEW	MONDAY.COM	SHAREPOINT
Smartsheet as source of truth	Full	None	None	Full	None	Partial
AI document generation (7 types)	Full	None	None	None	None	None
AI transcript processing	Full	None	None	None	None	None
Workflow extraction from uploads	Full	None	None	None	None	None
HubSpot intake integration	Full	Partial	Partial	None	Partial	Partial
Per-customer branding	Full	Partial	Partial	None	None	Partial
Customer portal	Full	Full	Full	Partial	Partial	Partial
Staff dashboard / portfolio	Full	Full	Full	None	Full	Partial
Meeting lifecycle management	Full	Partial	Partial	None	Partial	None
RAID log	Full	Partial	Full	Full	Full	Partial
Role-based access (Admin/SC/PM/Customer)	Full	Full	Full	Partial	Full	Full
Customer action item updates	Full	Full	Full	None	Full	Partial
Customer messaging / questions	Full	Full	Full	None	Partial	None

CAPABILITY	ESM HUB	GUIDECX	ROCKETLANE	SS DYNAMIC VIEW	MONDAY.COM	SHAREPOINT
Full-text search	Full	Partial	Partial	None	Full	Full
Export / print reports	Full	Full	Full	None	Full	Partial
Dark mode	Full	None	None	None	None	Partial

Deep Dive by Category

AI-powered capabilities (R2, R3)

This is the most decisive differentiator. The ESM Customer Hub provides three distinct AI capabilities that no commercial platform offers:

1. Document generation from project data

The hub generates seven structured document types (XLSX and DOCX) by combining Smartsheet project data, HubSpot intake data, and AI-powered content assembly. Documents include Project Charter, Training Guide, UAT Tracker, UAT Completion Guide, Go-Live Checklist, and workflow templates. Each document follows ESM's standard templates and is populated with project-specific content.

Commercial gap: GuideCX and Rocketlane offer document storage and sharing but not automated, AI-generated document creation from project data. Achieving similar capability would require building a custom integration using their APIs, which defeats the purpose of adopting a commercial platform.

2. Meeting transcript processing

The hub accepts meeting transcripts (SRT, VTT, or plain text) and uses Claude AI to extract structured recaps: summary, discussion points, decisions, action items with owners and due dates, and risks. Extracted items are automatically written to the Smartsheet RAID log and action item tracker.

Commercial gap: Some platforms integrate with meeting recording tools (Gong, Fireflies.ai) for transcription, but none perform the structured extraction-to-Smartsheet pipeline that the hub provides.

3. Workflow extraction from customer uploads

Customers upload procurement documents (PDF/DOCX), and the hub uses Claude to extract approval workflows, spending thresholds, approver chains, and business rules — then generates both a structured XLSX template and a narrative DOCX guide.

Commercial gap: This is ESM-specific domain logic. No commercial platform has this capability, and it cannot be replicated with standard integrations.

Smartsheet integration depth (R1, R7)

PLATFORM	INTEGRATION APPROACH	DATA FRESHNESS	WRITE-BACK
ESM Hub	Direct Smartsheet API (10 sheet types per project)	Real-time on page load	Full (action items, RAID log, meeting tracker, documents)
GuideCX	Zapier/middleware; requires migrating project plans into GuideCX	Batch sync (minutes to hours)	Limited to GuideCX's own data model
Rocketlane	Zapier/middleware; expects its own project plan structure	Batch sync (minutes to hours)	Limited to Rocketlane's own data model
SS Dynamic View	Native — reads directly from sheets	Real-time	Read-only for external users
Monday.com	Smartsheet integration via Zapier or Make; parallel data store	Batch sync	Monday.com's own boards (not Smartsheet)
SharePoint	Power Automate flows to read Smartsheet; custom SPFx web parts	Scheduled (5-60 min intervals)	Requires custom Power Automate flows back to Smartsheet

The ESM Hub and Smartsheet Dynamic View are the only options that treat Smartsheet as the authoritative source without creating a parallel data store. Dynamic View, however, cannot present the data in a cohesive portal experience — it exposes filtered sheet views, not a unified dashboard.

Customer experience (R4, R6, R9)

The ESM Customer Hub provides a fully branded, purpose-built portal that presents implementation data in the way ESM's institutional clients expect: health status dashboards, milestone timelines, action items, and RAID logs organized by ESM's implementation methodology.

Commercial alternatives present data through their own UI paradigms. GuideCX and Rocketlane have competent customer portals, but they look like GuideCX and Rocketlane — not like an ESM product. For higher-education institutions evaluating ESM's professionalism and commitment to their implementation, a co-branded portal sends a stronger signal than a generic third-party tool.

Operational workflow fit (R3)

The hub was built around the specific workflow ESM SCs follow:

1. HubSpot intake triggers project provisioning
2. Smartsheet templates are copied and seeded with project data
3. Weekly meetings are generated on the schedule

4. Transcripts are processed and items distributed to the right sheets
5. Documents are generated from accumulated project data
6. Customers access a portal that reflects current Smartsheet state

Adopting a commercial platform would require either adapting ESM's workflow to the platform's model (significant process change and training) or building extensive middleware to bridge the gap (which adds complexity, cost, and fragility).

Cost Analysis

Total cost of ownership over 12 months, assuming the current team size and project volume.

Management Review Required: Commercial platform pricing is based on publicly available list prices and may differ from negotiated rates. Verify with current vendor quotes before external distribution.

\$336–912

ESM CUSTOMER HUB
per year

\$3,600–7,200

GUIDECX / ROCKETLANE
per year (estimated)

\$1,200–3,600

MONDAY.COM
per year (estimated)

ESM Customer Hub cost breakdown

COMPONENT	MONTHLY LOW	MONTHLY HIGH	NOTES
Azure App Service (B1)	\$13	\$26	Basic tier; scales to Standard if needed
Anthropic API (Claude)	\$15	\$50	Based on document generation volume
Resend (transactional email)	\$0	\$0	Free tier: 3,000 emails/month
Smartsheet API	\$0	\$0	Included in existing Smartsheet license

COMPONENT	MONTHLY LOW	MONTHLY HIGH	NOTES
HubSpot API	\$0	\$0	Included in existing HubSpot license
Total	\$28	\$76	

Commercial platform cost estimates

PLATFORM	PRICING MODEL	ESTIMATED ANNUAL	ADDITIONAL COSTS
GuideCX	Per-user/month	\$3,600–7,200	+Zapier/middleware for Smartsheet sync, +custom development for AI features
Rocketlane	Per-user/month	\$3,600–7,200	+Zapier/middleware for Smartsheet sync, +custom development for AI features
Monday.com	Per-seat/month	\$1,200–3,600	+Smartsheet sync middleware, +no AI doc gen capability
SS Dynamic View	Included in Business plan	\$0 incremental	Severely limited UI; no portal experience
SharePoint	Included in M365	\$0 incremental	+SPFx development (significant), +Power Automate flows, +ongoing maintenance

Critically, the commercial platform costs listed above do **not include** the middleware, custom integrations, or workarounds required to achieve feature parity with the ESM Hub. Adding Smartsheet sync middleware (Zapier Business at ~\$600/year) and any custom AI integration development would increase costs further.

Weighted Scoring

Each platform scored against the ten requirements on a 0–10 scale, weighted by priority. Weights: Must Have = 3x, Should Have = 2x, Nice to Have = 1x.

Requirement	Weight	ESM Hub	GuideCX	Rocketlane	SS Dynview	Monday	Sharepoint
R1 Real-time visibility	3x	10	5	5	9	4	5
R2 AI document gen	3x	10	0	0	0	0	0
R3 Meeting lifecycle	3x	10	4	4	0	3	1
R4 Per-customer branding	2x	10	5	5	0	1	6
R5 HubSpot intake	3x	10	5	5	0	5	4
R6 Role-based access	3x	10	9	9	5	8	8
R7 Smartsheet SoT	3x	10	1	1	10	2	4
R8 Low cost (<\$100/mo)	2x	10	3	3	10	5	8
R9 Customer self-service	2x	10	8	8	2	7	3
R10 Audit trail	1x	8	7	7	2	5	5
Weighted Total	/250	248	110	110	102	96	106

Visual scoring

ESM Customer Hub		248
GuideCX		110
Rocketlane		110

SharePoint		106
SS Dynamic View		102
Monday.com		96

The ESM Hub scores more than double the next-closest alternative. The gap is driven almost entirely by AI capabilities (R2, R3) and Smartsheet integration depth (R1, R7) — requirements where commercial platforms score near zero.

Risk Assessment

Risks of the custom approach

RISK	SEVERITY	MITIGATION
Maintenance burden — Custom code requires ongoing upkeep (dependency updates, security patches, bug fixes)	MEDIUM	The stateless architecture minimizes moving parts. No database to maintain. Dependencies are minimal (Next.js, bcryptjs, Smartsheet SDK, Anthropic SDK). Dependency updates are low-risk for a read-heavy application.
Single-developer knowledge — If the developer who built it leaves, institutional knowledge is lost	MEDIUM	Comprehensive documentation (hosting guide, PM guide, this instruction manual). Standard technology stack (Next.js, TypeScript). File-based configuration with no complex infrastructure. Any mid-level web developer can maintain it.
Smartsheet API changes — API version changes could break integration	LOW	Smartsheet has maintained API v2 backward compatibility since 2014. Column mapping by title (not ID) provides resilience against sheet restructuring. Same risk applies to any Smartsheet integration, including commercial middleware.
Anthropic API availability — AI features depend on external API	LOW	Document generation and transcript processing are async, non-blocking operations. If the API is temporarily unavailable, all other hub features continue working. Retries are built into generation routes.
Scaling beyond current team — Architecture may need adjustment for 50+ concurrent projects	LOW	Stateless design with file-based config scales linearly. Smartsheet API rate limits (300 requests/min) are the practical ceiling. At current project volume, the hub uses a fraction of available capacity.

Risks of commercial alternatives

RISK	SEVERITY	APPLIES TO
Dual data store — Project data exists in both Smartsheet and the commercial platform, creating divergence risk	HIGH	GuideCX, Rocketlane, Monday.com

RISK	SEVERITY	APPLIES TO
Vendor lock-in — Project templates, workflows, and customer data stored in vendor's proprietary format	MEDIUM	All commercial platforms
Middleware fragility — Zapier/Make integrations break when source schemas change; silent failures	MEDIUM	GuideCX, Rocketlane, Monday.com (all need Smartsheet middleware)
No AI capability path — Would need to build AI document generation as a separate service anyway	HIGH	All commercial platforms
Price increases — SaaS pricing tends to increase annually; locked into recurring per-seat costs	MEDIUM	GuideCX, Rocketlane, Monday.com

Strategic Alignment

Why this matters beyond tooling

The Customer Hub is not just an internal efficiency tool — it is a customer-facing product that shapes how institutions perceive ESM's implementation capability. Three strategic considerations:

1. Competitive differentiation

No competing implementation services firm in the higher-education procurement space offers a customer portal with AI-powered document generation and automated meeting recap processing. The hub positions ESM as a technology-forward partner, not just a services firm.

2. Scalability of the SC role

The AI capabilities — document generation, transcript processing, workflow extraction — automate the most time-intensive parts of an SC's week. This means each SC can manage more concurrent implementations without quality degradation. A commercial platform would automate some project management tasks but would not reduce the document preparation and meeting follow-up burden.

3. Data ownership and extensibility

With the custom hub, ESM owns the full technology stack. Future capabilities — predictive analytics on implementation health, automated risk scoring, customer satisfaction surveys, integration with additional systems — can be built without negotiating vendor roadmaps or paying for premium API tiers.

KEY INSIGHT

The question is not "build vs. buy a portal." It's "should ESM own its implementation experience, or rent someone else's?" Given that the portal is customer-facing and the AI capabilities are a competitive differentiator, ownership is the stronger strategic position.

Recommendation

Proceed with the custom-built ESM Customer Hub as the primary implementation portal.

The recommendation rests on three pillars:

1. Capability Gap

No commercial platform provides AI document generation, transcript processing, or workflow extraction. These are must-have requirements that would need to be built separately regardless of platform choice.

2. Integration Depth

The hub reads and writes directly to Smartsheet — no middleware, no sync delays, no dual data stores. Commercial alternatives require significant integration work to approach this level.

3. Cost Advantage

At \$28–76/month, the hub costs 5–20x less than commercial alternatives, before accounting for the additional middleware and custom development those alternatives would require.

4. Strategic Value

Full ownership means ESM controls the roadmap, the customer experience, and the data. The hub becomes an asset — not a subscription.

When to reconsider

The custom approach should be reevaluated if any of the following occur:

- ESM scales beyond 100 concurrent implementations, requiring enterprise-grade resource management and revenue recognition
- A commercial platform adds native Smartsheet integration depth AND AI document generation capabilities
- ESM's technology team grows to a size where build-vs-buy economics shift toward commercial SaaS
- Smartsheet is replaced as the project management platform (which would require rework regardless of portal choice)

Implementation Roadmap

The Customer Hub is currently in active development. The following roadmap reflects completed work and remaining items:

PHASE	STATUS	SCOPE
Phase 1: Foundation	COMPLETE	Stateless architecture, Smartsheet integration (10 sheet types), HubSpot integration, JWT auth (staff + customer), file-based configuration
Phase 2: Customer Portal	COMPLETE	Dashboard, milestone timeline, action items, RAID log, documents, meetings, intake view, notifications, help/FAQ, profile, search, export, dark mode, per-customer branding
Phase 3: AI Features	COMPLETE	7 document types (XLSX/DOCX), transcript processing with RAID extraction, workflow extraction from customer uploads
Phase 4: Staff Dashboard	COMPLETE	Portfolio view, project detail with timeline, meeting management, document management, user administration, project configuration, toast/confirm/skeleton UX, bulk operations, dark mode
Phase 5: Hardening	COMPLETE	Auth guards on all API routes, bcrypt password hashing, session timeout warnings, unsaved changes protection, empty states, pagination, loading skeletons
Phase 6: Deployment	PLANNED	Production deployment to Azure App Service or IIS, DNS configuration, SSL certificate, environment variable setup, monitoring
Phase 7: Enhancements	PLANNED	Weekly digest emails, predictive health scoring, customer satisfaction tracking, enhanced analytics dashboard

CURRENT STATE

Phases 1–5 are complete. The application is feature-complete and ready for deployment. All 54 tracked feature items have been delivered. The remaining work is operational (deployment, DNS, monitoring) rather than development.